FIELD NOTE · 2026 · TRUST & SAFETY · COMMUNITY OPS

"Şehit": Reading the Behavior, Not the Word

In conflict-affected communities, a word alone cannot be the unit of decision; fair moderation judges the target, repetition, and effect of behavior, not the word or the side.

> *The word did not change; what changed was what was done with it.*

Running several online communities as both moderator and manager, one of the most important things I learned was this: the same word can be written with the same sincerity and still do completely different work. "Şehit" (martyr) was the clearest example.

The core meaning of the word is stable: remembrance and mourning. On its own it is not harmful. But both opposing sides of an armed conflict used it for their own dead. Here the word carried less a definition than a claim to legitimacy: for one side it meant "this dead person is the victim of a just cause," for the other, "I reject that cause."

So what one side wrote as remembrance could be read by the other as provocation. Historically loaded symbols worked the same way. Deciding which side was right was not the moderator's job, but deciding on the basis of a word or symbol meant, without realizing it, taking a side.

A word-based filter looked attractive. But the same word carried both remembrance and targeting. A filter that tries to silence one side can provoke several sides and make the team running the community look partisan. The word did not change; what changed was what was done with it. What set the cases apart was behavior: coordinated joining, fake accounts, and using numerical superiority to target a small number of people. Decisions rested on this behavior pattern, not on identity.

I treated reports as a second source; my main source was my own observation. I did not decide immediately and built up evidence instead. Meanwhile I took temporary calming measures against escalating behavior and told the reporting user that a review was ongoing. Newly created fake accounts often gave themselves away.

The same logic applied to other words. "Partizan" can mean both a partisan supporter of a side and a member of an armed resistance. "Gerilla" can refer to armed struggle in one context and to a low-budget growth tactic (guerrilla marketing) in another. "Cihad" (jihad) can be an inner spiritual struggle; read together with provocation, it can come across as a call to violence; and in a gaming chat it can be a playful exaggeration of an everyday struggle or rivalry. Same word, three contexts, three outcomes.

The weak point of this method is the cost of waiting. While evidence builds up, the targeted user can stay under pressure. I could not fully solve this; I could only reduce it with temporary measures. Still, my conclusion is this: deciding on the target, the repetition, and the effect of the behavior, rather than on the word or the side, is both fairer and more defensible.

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